

SATURDAY AT THE MOVIES.

(FIRST DRAFT)

Tell some youngster today that when you were his age it only cost a nickel to go to the movies on Saturday morning, and he'll think you're lying for sure. It ~~does~~^{is} probably ~~sound~~ hard to believe now, when theatre tickets average about three bucks a crack and popcorn costs fifty cents to a dollar. My, how things have changed.

The "nickle show" was what we called it in my town. We had three movie houses, The Poncan, The Murray, and The Rovy. The Rovy was the older of the three and also the smallest. But it was always packed every Saturday morning for the "nickle show." Kids would come from all parts of town. We would begin to descend upon the theatre about nine o'clock Saturday morning, either on foot or by bicycle. A few would arrive by car and be let off by their parents. The show started at 9:30 a.m. and usually lasted about two hours. In exchange for our nickle admission we would be shown a full length movie, one or two comedies and a serial. The movies were usually westerns with such stars as Tom Mix, Ken Maynard, Hoot Gibson, Tim McCoy, Johnny Mac Brown, or Irl Macrea. They were all larger than life heroes who always beat the bad guys before the movie ended.

the reason many of us went to the movies

The comedies we saw were ~~what a lot of us went for~~. We had Laurel and Hardy and Harold Lloyd; Buster Keaton, The Three Stooges, Dagwood and Blondie, Billie Gilbert, Edgar Kennedy, and a lot of others I don't remember.

We would also have one cartoon comedy, ~~to go with the one about real people~~. These were Mickey Mouse, or Popeye The Sailor, Porky Pig, Donald Duck,

The serial was a thriller which was continued each week for twelve episodes. You just had to go back each week to see if Buck Rogers or Flash Gordon got out of the real tight spot they were in when it ended the week before.

It was an excellent way to spend a Saturday morning, one which I am sure lots of parents in my hometown were grateful for. Still it wasn't always easy to come up with ten or fifteen cents for the show. You needed five cents for admission, then you needed money for a ~~popcorn bag~~ ^{sack of} or some candy to eat. Popcorn was the only thing sold in the movies then. There were no elaborate concession stands like we have today. They didn't even sell candy. If you wanted that, you went by Woolworth's or Kresges before the movie and bought your candy there. I used to go to Kresges and get a big bag of peanut butter kisses for five cents. This was approximately a quarter pound of candy. Each piece was about the size of your thumb end and was individually wrapped in a dark brown waxy paper. When you would untwist that wrapper the smell of the peanut butter and the nougat candy was sheer delight.

Over the years of my patronage at the nickel show I had devised several methods of raising the required funds to support my Saturday morning's entertainment. The first, and most obvious way was to ask my parents for the money. Sometimes, depending

upon various circumstances I might be given only the nickel for the show. This would leave me with the problem of raising popcorn and candy money to myself. There were times when I was denied even the basic five cents admission. I took this as being unfair and unjust and just downright ~~un-American~~ un-American to deny a young boy like myself the chance to help Hop-a-long Cassidy beat up on the cattle rustlers.

These were the times when my fool proof fund raising talents were put to the test. Soda pop bottles brought a nickel deposit for two bottles. Milk bottles were good for a nickel apiece at Hatfield's Grocery. And wire coat hangers would be purchased by the local drycleaners, two for a penny. These were big, heavy wire coat hangers, not the cheap flimsy kind you get today. Well, this took some scrounging around to find enough bottles - coat hangers were always my last resort. I always felt guilty carrying a bunch of wire coat hangers in to collect money for them. There were times though that I was forced to use the coat hangers to come up with just a nickel for the show. It also meant putting two or three pairs of my pants on one hanger and doing the same with some of my mother's dresses. She didn't much care for my efforts at rearranging her closet.

One night I was sitting in the big chair that was my father's ~~usual~~ ^{usual} ~~normal~~ ^{place} seating area and absent mindedly running my fingers down between the cushion and the side of the chair I felt what was unmistakably coins resting in the bottom of that big chair.

I stood up, lifted the cushion and saw a veritable treasure trove. There were several pennies, three ~~gms~~ ~~gms~~ nickels and two dimes. No telling how long they had rested there, just waiting to be put to good use. I took the coins and put them in my pocket. What should I do? Were they mine to keep, or did they rightfully belong to my father from whose pockets they had fallen?

I agonized over this for several days before making my decision. I looked upon the coins as lost property, and since I was the finder, I would also be the keeper. In later years I told my dad about this. ~~My father and I~~ We had a good laugh about it, he didn't seem to mind.